

NEIGHBOURS PAKISTAN

want to read it and thought he could somehow manage to hold on to the levers of power till the tide turned in his favour again. The past two months though saw the ground shift decisively from under his feet. Everyone still believed that he had some tricks up his sleeve when the ruling coalition decided to press for his impeachment. There were even rumours that he was prepared to exercise his powers as the President to dismiss the National Assembly if they moved against him. His arch rival, Nawaz Sharif, thought he would put up a big fight. As Sharif told *INDIA TODAY*, "We were prepared for the worst but he surprised me by just running away." (See interview)



WHY MUSHARRAF SIMPLY HAD TO GO

Musharraf had concluded that the game was up the night before he put in his papers and took his wife, children and his mother into confidence. The next day he gave a clue of his decision in the recitation from the Quran that preceded his speech. True to the history of critical speeches in the country, the verses had been picked with great care. "A special place (in heaven) is reserved for those who do not desire greatness on Earth," translated the qazi, "and those who do not desire strife." Forty-five



ZARDARI MAY HAVE GAINED BY THE SMOOTH OUSTER, BUT JUDICIAL REST

NEW LORDS:
Zardari (left),
Bilawal Bhutto
and Sharif after
Musharraf's
resignation

minutes into his speech, after recounting his achievements and declaring that no charges against him could stick, President Musharraf resigned "in the greater national interest."

Musharraf would have done his battered image some good if he had gracefully quit after the King's Party, the Pakistan Muslim League(Q) that he had propped up, was swept out of power in February's general elections. Even more mortifying to him was that the two main winners, Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP) led by Asif Zardari, the widower of Benazir Bhutto, and PML(N) chaired by Nawaz Sharif, were the very foes that he had indicted when he grabbed power. But differences arose between the two parties over the issue of the restoration of judiciary sacked by Musharraf on November 3 last year when he imposed the so-called "emergency" giving him some hope.

The judges issue, "rule of law", was the basis on which the entire anti-Musharraf movement had been built and on whose coat-tails the politicians had rode on. But in the aftermath of the elections it became proxy to the battle for dominance between Zardari and Sharif. Sharif had been itching to settle scores with Musharraf for ousting him

from power in 1999 and sending him to an ignominious exile in Jeddah for seven years. He knew that if the judges were restored, they could move the Supreme Court to declare invalid the 2007 election pushed through by Musharraf to stay on as President. Musharraf had brushed aside the law barring a serving officer from standing for the nation's highest post.

The PPP, especially Zardari, was wary of reinstating the sacked Supreme Court chief justice, Iftikhar Chaudhary, who had become the symbol of defiance for the agitating lawyers. Among Zardari's concerns was that the reinstated Chaudhary may undo the National Reconciliation Ordinance (NRO) which Musharraf had issued absolving Zardari and Bhutto of criminal charges—something Chaudhary had indicated he would do before his ouster. Zardari was also upset with the judiciary in the way they treated his pleas in the 11 years that he spent in jail. He had dismissed the demand for the restoration of judiciary "as trivial" when compared to the larger reforms that he wanted including getting the Parliament to oversee the appointment of superior judges. So he and Musharraf found themselves on the same side of